

THE VINE — Operating Budget

Athens, Tennessee | Established Phase | Annual Target \$130,000 | Frugal, Sustainable, Generous

"For which of you, desiring to build a tower, does not first sit down and count the cost, whether he has enough to complete it?" — Luke 14:28

We counted the cost for launch. Now we count the cost to thrive, to stay healthy, and to send.

GUIDING PHILOSOPHY

This is the operating budget for a maturing congregation. The launch season (with its lean, bi-vocational, portable skeleton crew model) has done its work. This budget assumes we have gathered a core of 110–160 regular attenders, local giving has strengthened, and we are ready to invest in people, presence, and outward mission without apology — while remaining deliberately frugal.

Core convictions for established operations:

1. **People deserve real support.** A modest but respectable ministerial line plus part-time support staff multiplies the ministry, protects the pastor from burnout, and honors the work. We still expect vocation and lay leadership to carry much of the load — paid roles exist to equip and free the body, not replace it.
2. **10% savings is a tithe, not a suggestion.** Before we expand programs or staff or even give to missions, we set aside the first tenth for resilience. This builds a true operating reserve, seeds future capital needs, and lets us say “yes” to God-given opportunities without panic or debt.
3. **Missions is who we are.** Nearly 15% of the total budget leaves the building — local mercy, national partnerships, and global workers. We are not a church that exists to consume

resources. We exist to give them away.

- 4. **Frugal is still a spiritual discipline.** Every line item below has been pressure-tested: Can volunteers or in-house skill cover it? Can we buy once and maintain well? Is this producing actual fruit in people’s lives? We refuse to let overhead quietly become the mission.
- 5. **Growth with margin.** The numbers are sized for 120–180 average weekly attendance with breathing room. They allow us to add capacity (more kids resources, stronger hospitality, one additional part-time role) before the next major revision. We do not grow into desperation.

This budget lives in the \$120,000–\$140,000 band because that is the realistic, healthy range for a small-to-mid-size church in rural/semi-rural East Tennessee that wants to be excellent, generous, and reproducible.



BUDGET SUMMARY

BUILDINGS	SALARIES	OPERATIONS	MISSIONS	
\$16,800	\$55,200	\$26,100	\$18,900	\$
(12.9%)	(42.5%)	(20.1%)	(14.5%)	(
+-----+	+-----+	+-----+	+-----+	
\$130,000 TOTAL				



Category	Annual	Monthly	% of Total	Notes
Buildings	\$16,800	\$1,400	12.9%	Rental + secure storage
Salaries	\$55,200	\$4,600	42.5%	Ministerial, support, taxes & insurance
Operations	\$26,100	\$2,175	20.1%	All 19 administrative & ministry support lines
Missions	\$18,900	\$1,575	14.5%	Local / National / Global / Discretionary
Subtotal	\$117,000	\$9,750	90.0%	Core operating spend
Savings (10%)	\$13,000	\$1,083	10.0%	Reserve & future fund (non-negotiable)
TOTAL	\$130,000	\$10,833	100%	

All figures are annual targets. Monthly amounts are for cash-flow planning and are not rigid silos.

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BUILDINGS

Rental and Storage

We remain a portable church by conviction. We rent space that allows excellent gatherings without owning a building we cannot yet sustain. Storage protects the significant equipment investment made in the launch phase and keeps weekly setup/teardown sane.

Line Item	Monthly	Annual	Notes / Frugality Lever
Rental (primary meeting space + utilities/cleaning share)	\$1,200	\$14,400	School gym, community center, trade center, or similar multi-use venue. 1–2 services + midweek. We negotiate shared utility/cleaning fees rather than full commercial rates. Portable = we can exit if terms deteriorate.
Storage (gear, trailer parking, supplies, seasonal overflow)	\$200	\$2,400	Secure, weather-protected space for the enclosed cargo trailer, audio cases, stage sections, kids equipment, tables, and hospitality totes. A small unit or shared garage/warehouse bay beats paying for damage or replacement.
BUILDINGS SUBTOTAL	\$1,400	\$16,800	~13% of total budget. Still dramatically lower than a mortgage or full commercial lease.

Frugality note: We review the rental arrangement every 12 months. If a better (or cheaper) venue appears that still serves the mission, we move. Storage is sized exactly to what we actually own — no speculative expansion.

SALARIES

Ministerial • Dental and Health Insurance • Support Salaries • Payroll Taxes • Workmen's Compensation Insurance

People are the ministry. This is the largest category because compensating called leaders well (even if modestly by national standards) is both faithful and strategic. All figures assume a small-church, East Tennessee cost of living and a still-partially-bi-vocational posture.

Line Item	Monthly	Annual	Notes / Frugality Lever
Ministerial (salary + housing allowance)	\$3,000	\$36,000	Structured to maximize tax efficiency where possible (housing allowance for eligible portions). This is meaningful support, not a “market” full-time senior pastor package. Still assumes some personal income from vocation or other work. The goal is sustainability without entitlement.
Dental and Health Insurance	\$500	\$6,000	Marketplace or ministry-shared plan (GuideStone, Brotherhood, etc.). Church contribution toward pastor + family coverage. Shopped annually. High-deductible + HSA strategy where it makes sense.
Support Salaries (part-time admin / worship-tech / kids support)	\$700	\$8,400	One or two part-time roles (combined ~15–20 hrs/week total). These exist to multiply lay leaders and handle recurring admin/tech/kids logistics, not to create a staff-heavy model. Roles are reviewed every 6 months against actual need and giving.
Payroll Taxes	\$300	\$3,600	Employer FICA (7.65%), federal/state unemployment, and any payroll processing fees. Calculated on actual wages paid.
Workmen's Compensation Insurance	\$100	\$1,200	TN-mandated for churches with employees. Shopped through church insurers; rates are modest for our risk profile (mostly low-hazard admin and light event work).
SALARIES SUBTOTAL	\$4,600	\$55,200	42.5% of total budget. Largest single category by design — and still lean for the scope of ministry.

Frugality & philosophy notes: - We do not add additional paid roles until local giving has covered the current full budget + the new line item for at least four consecutive months plus a three-month cash reserve. - All paid staff (including the pastor) submit simple monthly activity reports to the leadership/elders. Transparency builds trust. - Benefits stay modest until the church can comfortably sustain them without cutting missions or savings.

OPERATIONS

Accounting • Advertising • Bank Fees • Bibles • Phone • Credit Card Processing • Equipment Maintenance • Hospitality • Liability Insurance • Internet Service • Legal Support • Kids Supplies • Offering Envelopes • Office Supplies • Guest Management Software • Printing • Financial Software • Travel and Conferences • Web Hosting

Nineteen distinct lines. Every one is necessary for health and hospitality; none is extravagant. In-house skills (tech, design, administration) keep many of these numbers far below national averages for churches of similar size.

Line Item	Monthly	Annual	Notes / Frugality Lever
Accounting	\$125	\$1,500	Fractional bookkeeper or trusted local CPA for monthly reconciliation + quarterly review. QuickBooks or equivalent + year-end 1099s/990 prep. We do not run the books ourselves long-term — integrity matters.
Advertising	\$300	\$3,600	Ongoing visibility per PUBLICITY-GUIDE.md: radio packages (seasonal), targeted social boosts, occasional print, yard signs, and Eventbrite/Meetup where useful. Heavy emphasis on free/organic channels first.
Bank Fees	\$25	\$300	Business checking, ACH, wire, and deposit fees. Choose a local or credit-union partner that understands nonprofits and keeps fees low.
Bibles	\$65	\$780	Bulk ESV / NIV / CSB purchases for new believers, Branches, guest gifts, and “The Open Table.” We buy quality but not leather-bound excess.
Phone	\$50	\$600	Dedicated church mobile number (or Google Voice + hardware) with professional voicemail and texting capability. One number for the community to reach us.

Credit Card Processing	\$185	\$2,220	Platform fees + 2.2–2.9% on tithes/offerings processed (est. on \$70k–\$85k annual giving). We pass no convenience fees to givers; we absorb it as a cost of modern generosity.
Equipment Maintenance	\$165	\$1,980	Audio repairs, trailer tires/brakes/lights, chair refurbishment, cable replacement, power distribution fixes, seasonal deep-clean of gear. Buy once, maintain forever.
Hospitality	\$235	\$2,820	Weekly coffee/tea/cold brew, snacks for gatherings and Respawn/Basecamp, welcome gifts and visitor packet refills, paper goods, tablecloths, serving supplies. The “taste” of welcome matters.
Liability Insurance	\$265	\$3,180	General liability, event coverage, D&O, equipment floater, and any landlord-required riders. Shopped annually (Church Mutual, Brotherhood, GuideOne, etc.). Higher than launch phase because we have more public activity.
Internet Service	\$60	\$720	Venue Wi-Fi contribution or dedicated hotspot/backup plan for planning nights, streaming tests, and admin work. Often bundled or low-cost in shared spaces.
Legal Support	\$50	\$600	Annual compliance review, occasional attorney consult for contracts or employment questions, state charitable solicitation renewal if required. Mostly preventive.
Kids Supplies	\$150	\$1,800	Curriculum printing, craft refills, diapers/wipes, snacks, cleaning supplies, safety items, rotating toys/books, check-in labels, first-aid restock. Safety and warmth first.
Offering Envelopes	\$35	\$420	Annual bulk order of offering envelopes (dated or generic) plus special giving envelopes for missions emphasis or year-end. Low-cost local printer.

Local • National • Global • Discretionary

This is not leftover money. Missions is a first-fruits conviction. We decide the missions budget at the beginning of the year and protect it.

Line Item	Monthly	Annual	Notes / Frugality Lever
Local	\$600	\$7,200	Benevolence (gas, groceries, car repair, utility help for known families), ongoing support for Love Thy Neighbor Project / TWU Food Bank, H.O.P.E. Center, Good Faith Clinic, festival servant team supplies, neighborhood cookout food, and emergency mercy response. Every dollar is tracked and stories (anonymized) are reported to the church.
National	\$350	\$4,200	Domestic missions: disaster relief (when events hit), support for other church plants in our network or denomination, ministries to the imprisoned, trafficked, or homeless in the U.S., and any national initiatives the leadership team adopts after prayer and vetting.
Global	\$375	\$4,500	Long-term commitments to 2–3 missionaries or global projects (roughly \$100–\$150/mo each). Child sponsorship collectives, clean water, Bible translation, or church-planting movements. We prefer fewer, deeper relationships over many small gifts. The church “owns” these partners.
Discretionary	\$250	\$3,000	Pastor/elder-directed fund for immediate, undocumented, or Spirit-prompted needs that do not fit other categories. Accounted for publicly after the fact (amount + general purpose, no names). This is the “go and do likewise” money.
MISSIONS SUBTOTAL	\$1,575	\$18,900	14.5% of total budget — and one of the first places we increase when giving exceeds plan.

Frugality & conviction notes: - We never reduce missions to balance the budget. If we must cut, we cut operations or (in extremis) slow salary growth first. - Local missions stays relational: we know the people or the partner agency personally. No anonymous grants to faceless organizations. - Global and national partners are presented to the congregation regularly — names, faces, specific prayer requests. Giving is personal, not institutional.

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SAVINGS (10%)

\$13,000 / year — \$1,083 / month

This line is non-negotiable. It is the church's tithe to its own future and resilience.

Intended uses (in priority order): 1. True operating reserve (target: 3–6 months of core expenses before any expansion). 2. Emergency repairs or uninsured losses (trailer, audio, venue damage, etc.). 3. Seed capital for a future permanent meeting space or major equipment refresh (when the time is right and the congregation is ready). 4. Strategic one-time opportunities (a building that becomes available, a missions crisis, a church plant we are called to support).

Rules: - Savings is spent only by documented leadership/elder decision. - Any draw over \$2,000 is reported to the full church body with rationale and a replenishment plan. - We do not “borrow” from savings to cover recurring shortfalls. Recurring gaps trigger immediate review of income and expenses.

By year three of consistent operation at this level, the savings line alone will have built a \$35k–\$40k reserve — real freedom and real stewardship.

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INCOME ASSUMPTIONS & SUSTAINABILITY

This budget assumes the following steady-state reality (post-launch, established phase):

- Average weekly attendance (adults + kids): 120–160 sustained.
- Average monthly giving per adult attender: \$35–\$42 (realistic small-town mix of committed tithers, regular givers, young adults, and visitors; includes both tithes and offerings).
- Projected stable local giving: \$6,000 – \$7,500 per month (\$72,000 – \$90,000 / year).
- The gap between local giving and the \$10,833 monthly need is closed by:
 - Continued (but tapering) network support from the original launch team
 - Any remaining designated first-year or second-year operating gifts

- Growth in per-capita giving as people mature in generosity
- Occasional special offerings or year-end pushes

Health marker: When local giving consistently covers 95%+ of the full \$130k budget (including savings) for four consecutive months with a three-month reserve already in the bank, the church is financially healthy and self-sustaining.

SCALING ASSUMPTIONS & TRIGGERS

We do not grow the budget because we *want* to. We grow the budget when reality (attendance + giving + Spirit) makes it necessary and sustainable.

Trigger	Budget Impact	Notes
Sustained 180+ weekly attendance (3+ months)	+\$600–1,200/mo (larger rental or second service logistics, more kids/hospitality, potential additional part-time role)	Only after local giving has covered the <i>new</i> total for 4 months + 3-month reserve
Adding a second meaningful part-time staff role	+\$1,000–1,800/mo (salary + taxes + benefits)	Same rule as above
Moving to a more permanent or higher-cost venue	+\$800–2,500+/mo (rent + utilities + maint)	Requires capital campaign + elder recommendation + 12-month reserve
Full-time ministerial compensation	+\$2,500–4,000/mo (salary + full benefits)	Only when local giving reliably covers \$12k–14k/mo+ for 6+ months
Major missions expansion	+\$300–600/mo per new commitment	Funded by giving above budget or one-time gifts, not by cutting other categories

Iron rule: No new recurring expense is added until the current budget plus the new line has been covered by local giving for four consecutive months with a three-month cash reserve already built.

STRATEGIES FOR KEEPING COSTS LOW (AND MISSION HIGH)

1. **In-house everything possible.** Tech, design, website, graphics, basic streaming, some printing, admin systems, even audio maintenance — the same skills that kept launch costs low continue to suppress monthly overhead.
 2. **Volunteer first, paid second.** Setup/teardown, hospitality, kids check-in, mercy response, social media, calendar work, even some accounting prep — done by Branches and regular attendees. Paid staff exist to equip and coordinate, not to do all the work.
 3. **Maintenance over replacement.** The launch equipment budget was sized for 7–10 years of heavy weekly use. We repair before we replace. We store and transport carefully.
 4. **Relational benevolence.** The \$7,200 local missions line goes a long way because it is targeted at real, known people through known leaders. No large institutional fund that loses the relational component.
 5. **Quarterly zero-based review.** Every 90 days the leadership team walks line-by-line through actuals vs. budget. Anything not producing clear fruit (relationships, conversions, community goodwill, safety, or necessary administration) is reduced or cut.
 6. **Share or borrow before buying.** Outfitter group rates, partner agency space, borrowed tables/chairs for big events, co-op advertising with other churches or nonprofits when it makes sense.
 7. **Annual insurance & software shopping.** Never auto-renew without comparing at least two other providers. Ministry-specific insurers and church software vendors often beat consumer rates.
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STEWARDSHIP & TRANSPARENCY

- Quarterly financial updates (income, expenses by major category, missions impact, savings balance) sent to all donors and presented to the congregation.

- Annual budget presented to the church body once elders/leadership team are in place.
- Every local missions/benevolence dollar tracked and reported (anonymized stories and aggregate totals).
- Open books policy: any regular attender or donor may request to see the actuals with reasonable notice.
- We will adjust this budget publicly (and explain why) if reality requires it — higher rent, lower giving, a major new opportunity, or a crisis.

We treat other people's money as sacred because it is.

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WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE (ESTABLISHED PHASE)

- Local giving sustains the full \$130,000 (including the 10% savings) with margin and joy.
- Missions dollars are actively at work and the church celebrates specific stories of impact — local families helped, national partners strengthened, global workers supported.
- Paid staff (pastor + part-time support) feel resourced, appreciated, and able to focus on the parts of ministry that only they can do.
- A genuine 3–6 month operating reserve exists and grows in good years.
- The church can say “yes” to a new neighbor in crisis or a new missions opportunity because we planned for generosity.
- No one in the core feels financial pressure from the church — the church is a source of life and sending, not anxiety.
- We are still portable, still relationally driven, still weird enough to reach the people who don't fit anywhere else — and now we have the structural health to do it for the long haul.

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"The earth is the Lord's, and everything in it."

We budget, we spend, we save, and we give because none of it ultimately belongs to us.

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Document prepared for The Vine Church — Athens, Tennessee

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Companion to: FUNDRAISING.md • THE-VINE-LAUNCH-BUDGET.md • THE-VINE-OUTREACH-PLAN.md • THE-VINE-PUBLICITY-GUIDE.md

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"I am the vine; you are the branches. If you remain in me and I in you, you will bear much fruit."

— John 15:5

Budget last revised for established-phase operations — \$120k–\$140k target band with 10% savings.